Cora Piantoni
The Stokers

Jiri Kovanda, Prague, 2007

Viktor Kolar, Ostrava, 2008

Rudolf Valenta, Berlin, 2008

Jaroslav Hutka, Prague, 2008

The meaning of the word „dissident“ has changed: not a political activist, but to be a responsible citizen.
I always wanted to be an artist more than a political activist.
Being political means to do the best at your position for the development of your surrounding.
Being an artist was a way to find myself, my cooperation with the world.

Petr Kvicala

The political situation was difficult, but the other world was completely unknown to me.
In my work, I preferred unpolitical topics (nature, landscape and people).
I was only 5 months in the military, afterwards I worked as a stoker, because that was a calm service. I could read and draw. The money was not so important.

Ladislav Sykora

The artists and philosophers were stokers, but normal people had only one possibility: career at work and in the society. Good humans made what the regime wanted. We weren't good, up to now. All actions were maps where it goes in the terrain: not in the center, in the periphery. The situation was: best musicians, best poets, best young people, everybody was together at the edge of the Prague scene. All were not completely forbidden, but a little, excluded from the public area. Excommunication: not yet criminal, only with a foot in prison.

Vera Jirousova

Our actions were private, no written invitations. Exhibitions were only possible unofficially at private places like cellars and flats or sometimes semiofficially at scientific institutions and youth clubs for example. The artists had strong contact amongst each other.

Jiri Kovanda

For me, art activities were a means of expression, a way to be free and to live free in this concentration camp called Czechoslovak Socialistic (better: Soviet) Republic, a means of non-verbal communication with people with similar thoughts and feelings and abroad. It's a terrible, awful idea. I'm sick of it, really, but it must be said here: without the stupid communist regime of 1970s I would never have started to do the things I did that time! Seen this way, my work was „political", a reaction of mind and body trying to be as free as possible.

Petr Stembera

Vera Jirousova, Prague, 2008

Vlasta Tresnak, Prague, 2008

Ladislav Sykora, Desenice, 2007

Petr Kvicala, Brno, 2007

Tomas Ruller, Brno, 2008

1950 I should go to military service. A few months after my arrival they accused me of being a spy. I learned English before. In addition I drew. From the barrack's window I drew the landscape or my colleagues, the soldiers, our bedroom. There were 5 beds on top of each other, that was wonderful for me to draw the construction going gradually upward. The drawings were then shown in court as corpus delicti. The largest irony was: this coalmine was called „progress “. An age-old name. First the prisoners were there and later those, whom the system did not like.

Rudolf Valenta

I wrote political songs, but funny ones. That was particularly bad. Humor is something intolerable for a dictatorship. They cannot understand humor.
Since the year 1975 I had several criminal procedures at the neck. The first was for „disparagement of the people, the race and the conviction“, due to the perception of Easter in the old Moravian ballads. Later I was accused of „illegal enterprise“. At the police questioning I asked: „The old folk songs are also a provocation?“ The interrogater answered: „If you sing them, then they are directed also against the state.“ I did thus very well to sing these songs,

because in the moment I had saved them. Up to then, the communist regime stated to be the owner of folklore. Suddenly I had stolen it. From that moment it belonged to me. That was the liberation of the folklore.

Jaroslav Hutka

This Prague Spring time was inspiring. It were really times when you understand what it means when people feel like one person, when they have so much in common, they share everything and this closeness is literally the truth. When you don't see these controversial things going on, when you see no difference between social groups, even under this communist philosophy, which was based totally on the conflict between social groups.

Jiri Kolar

Communism and capitalism can restrict in a similar extent. One means ideological press, second means economic stress. That is a little slogan for me. But art is only good or bad. The main topic for the art is not the political situation. I am a type who only made the middle school. I am from a politically problematic family, I did not study at an academy. I was alone with my topic.

Very positive at these group exhibitions in 1981-83 was the friendship, cooperative friendship, work friendship. I like this social context, which doesn’t exist any longer. This normal contact, normal humor, normal confrontation and naturally normal topic, literary or political. I am content, but absolutely not everything from old times is bad.

Ivan Kafka

These performances from the middle and late ‘80s were about opposition through cultural participation, concentrating on non-political actions. The cultural system was so politicized that the official propaganda stated that art must serve ideology. Our activity was totally in opposition to this aesthetic concept, not only to the political system. Of course the desired service or practice was to adore or portray the authority of communism. We concentrated on doing something like art for art’s sake. There was a big freedom in doing that.

Tomas Ruller

Ivan Kafka, Prague, 2008

Jiri Valoch, Brno, 2008

Cora Piantoni

The Stokers
Life and Work of Czech Artists 1950-1989

The texts are quotations from interviews with the artists and Cora Piantoni, except of the interview with Petr Stembera, which is reprinted with friendly permission from the exhibition catalogue “Short Careers / Kurze Karrieren”, Ed. Susanna Neuburger, Hedwid Saxenhuber for MUMOK Museum Moderner Kunst Stiftung Ludwig, Vienna, Verlag der Buchhandlung Walther Koenig, Cologne, 2004, pp.104-105 and the interview with Jaroslav Hutka, which is reprinted with friendly permission from the book “Dissidenten, Präsidenten und Gemüsehändler”, Ed. Doris Liebermann, Jürgen Fuchs, Vlasta Wallat, Klartext Verlag, Essen, 1998, pp. 119-120

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